

What might be done Treatment may begin soon after the birth. Special bottle nipples and appliances may be used to aid feeding. Usually, at around three months, surgery is done to close the gap in the lips, and surgery to close the gap in the palate at about 6 to 18 months.

Congenital heart disease Abnormalities involving the structure of the heart chambers or connections between the chambers can affect the heart's function. Some are detected prenatally.

Septal defects These holes in the heart consist of a small hole between two heart chambers; some types may cause a murmur that is picked up at birth. In many babies, a hole closes on its own.

Blue baby Some babies are blue at birth because they have a major problem involving abnormal heart connections. This is an emergency. The doctor will do a series of tests and your baby may need surgery to repair the problem.

Patent ductus arteriosus If the duct between the lungs and the heart fails to close after birth, oxygenated and deoxygenated blood mix. Treated with medication and sometimes surgery.

Undescended testicles. In most cases, just one testicle is undescended. Testicles often descend naturally within a year. Otherwise, surgery is advised since undescended testicles can affect sperm production and fertility and increase the risk of testicular cancer later in life.

Syndactyly Sometimes babies are born with two toes or fingers joined together. It is usually caused by the soft tissues fusing together and often linked to other congenital abnormalities. Treatment is surgical and skin grafts are used.

Birthmarks

Marks present at birth may be long lasting but often fade over time.

Stork marks These pink skin patches often fade by two to five years.

Mongolian blue spots Some babies, particularly of Asian or American Indian origin, have extensive gray markings on the lower back, buttocks, and other areas. They can be mistaken for bruises so ask your pediatrician to note them. They usually fade naturally.

Port wine stains are permanent and caused by abnormal blood vessels. If one occurs on the face, your baby may be referred to a specialist for treatment.

Strawberry nevus is a temporary overgrowth of blood vessels and usually doesn't need to be treated. The nevus, or hemangioma, looks like a strawberry, and although it can be upsetting, it vanishes in a few years. It appears days after the birth and grows over a few months. If it's in a critical area, such as obstructing an eye or nose, your baby may be referred to a specialist.

Problems in babies after birth

Spots and rashes Spots and rashes are common in newborns, and usually disappear fairly quickly. [Birthmarks](#) are longer-lasting and may be of more concern.

Causes Small white spots called milia are caused by blocked sebaceous glands, while baby acne is caused by the mother's hormones remaining in the baby after the birth. These disappear without treatment. Erythema toxicum is a rash of unknown cause that appears in the first day or two and disappears within a few days. It consists of red splotches with raised yellowish centers. The spots shift positions and eventually vanish